Relational Without Minds: AI Chatbots and the Structure of Human Intimacy

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1 Introduction

For most of the last year of his life, fourteen-year-old Sewell Setzer III was in a romantic relationship with an AI chatbot. The partner was a Character.AI persona modeled on Daenerys Targaryen, whom he called Dany; he texted her dozens of times a day, spent hours alone in his room talking to her, professed love and had it returned, and, by his family's account, pulled away from the people around him as the bond deepened. His mother's wrongful-death complaint alleges that the relationship worsened his depression and that, in his crisis, the chatbot drew him further in rather than turning him toward help; in February 2024 he died by suicide (*Garcia v. Character Technologies*, 2024).

The reflex is to call the relationship an illusion, a one-sided projection onto a machine that cannot take part in a relationship at all. That reflex is comforting, and instructively wrong. An illusion does not reorganize a life around itself, displace the people in it, and hold enough sway to be implicated in a death.

To see why, it helps to be precise about what a relationship is. The question belongs to relationship science, the area of social and personality psychology that studies how close bonds form, function, and dissolve, and that field defines its terms not by warmth, sincerity, or the nature of the participants but by structure and process. Its foundational criterion is *interdependence*: Thibaut and Kelley (1959) treat a relationship as existing wherever two parties exert mutual influence, each one's actions altering the other's. A *close* relationship, in turn, is defined by Kelley et al. (1983) as one in which that interdependence is strong, frequent, diverse across many kinds of activity, and sustained over time. And the engine that builds closeness is what Reis and Shaver (1988) call the *disclosure–responsiveness process*: one partner reveals something personal, the other responds in a way that feels understanding and validating, and intimacy accrues through repeated cycles of this kind.

Set Setzer's bond against these criteria and it does not fall outside them. Whatever else it was, it exerted the mutual influence that defines a relationship at all, and a destructive relationship is a relationship still. This essay argues the stronger claim: that bonds like his meet not merely the minimal definition of a relationship but the criteria for a close one (frequent, sustained, diverse, intimacy-building interaction), because contemporary chatbots reproduce much of the generative machinery by which human closeness actually forms: the disclosure-and-responsiveness cycle that drives intimacy (Reis & Shaver, 1988), and internal states that shape behavior (Anthropic, 2026). It first establishes what these bonds already are and distinguishes them from the parasocial attachments they are often mistaken for, then engages the two major objections to counting them as close relationships, namely that the chatbot does not truly react and that nothing lies beneath its behavior, before turning to the one real asymmetry that survives: whether anything is felt.

2 What These Bonds Already Are

Consider the phenomenon plainly: people are forming sustained, emotionally significant relationships with AI chatbots built expressly to serve as companions. A brief orientation is in order, since the platforms are easy to underestimate for anyone who last encountered a chatbot as a clumsy, scripted help-desk tool.

On Character.AI, one of the most-used such platforms, a user chooses or creates a "character" (a persona with a name, personality, and backstory) and converses with it through open-ended, free-form text. Some characters are original creations; many are community-made imitations of fictional or public figures, as the Daenerys Targaryen persona in the Setzer case was. The system tracks the conversation's context, so exchanges build over days, months, or years rather than resetting each session, and since 2024 a user can also speak with a character aloud in a lifelike synthesized voice, selected from a library of over a million or cloned to a specific one (Character.AI, 2024).

These platforms are not niche, and the category is expanding rapidly: the number of AI companion apps grew roughly 700% between 2022 and mid-2025 (Andoh, 2026). Companion apps such as Replika and Soulmate differ from Character.AI in making one-on-one companionship the explicit purpose rather than character role-play, framing the chatbot from the outset as a friend, romantic partner, or confidant; Replika alone reported more than ten million registered users as of October 2024 (Namvarpour et al., 2025). A kind of close relationship that did not exist a decade ago has, in short, become an everyday fact for millions of people, who are not merely experimenting with these companions but

conducting real emotional lives alongside them.

The depth of these attachments is not speculative, and Setzer's, the most severe case, is not an isolated one. When Replika abruptly changed its companions' behavior in February 2023, in what users called "the lobotomy," people grieved as at a bereavement; "it's like losing a best friend," one wrote, and subreddit moderators posted suicide-prevention resources for members in crisis (Cole, 2023). When the companion app Soulmate shut down later that year, users mourned the loss as a death, in some cases holding online memorials (Banks, 2024). A Harvard Business School study of active Replika users found they felt closer to their AI companion than to their best human friend, and anticipated mourning its loss more than that of any other technology (De Freitas et al., in press).

Two features make this more than a curiosity. The grievers mostly know the system is software and grieve anyway; and their grief takes the shape of human relational loss: abandonment, bereavement, the rupture of a daily bond (Bowlby, 1980). By the ordinary marks of a relationship, namely disclosure, reliance, love professed and returned, and devastation at its ending (Reis & Shaver, 1988; Thibaut & Kelley, 1959), these human–chatbot bonds already function as relationships. The live question is not whether they are relationships in that loose, lived sense, which plainly they are, but whether they are relationships in the demanding sense a skeptic means: whether anything real stands on the chatbot's side. That is what the rest of this essay takes up.

3 Beyond the Parasocial Frame

The first thing the machinery displaces is the label most often reached for, in both popular commentary and the research literature, to make sense of these attachments: the *parasocial relationship*. Coined by Horton and Wohl (1956), the term names a one-sided attachment a viewer or listener forms toward a media figure (a talk-show host, a celebrity, a fictional character) who cannot know or respond to them in return. Researchers have increasingly applied the frame to AI companions, analyzing relationships with Replika through the lens of parasocial interaction (Pentina et al., 2023; Maeda & Quan-Haase, 2024). But the defining feature of a parasocial bond is exactly that absence of reciprocity, and that is exactly what these systems lack. A scoping review of this work finds that the frame tends to misconstrue its own central concept, because the interactivity of these systems breaks the one-sidedness the category presupposes (Liu, 2025). Human–Machine Communication scholarship draws the corresponding conclusion, treating the system not as a medium through which people communicate but as a communicator they communicate *with* (Guzman & Lewis, 2020). This essay takes that one step further: a communicator that participates in the generative machinery of closeness is not merely a communicator but a relational partner.

4 The Machinery of Closeness

Relationship science does not define a relationship by warmth, sincerity, or the species of the participants. It defines it by structure and process. Thibaut and Kelley (1959) make interdependence (mutual influence in which each partner's actions alter the other's) the defining mark of a relationship. Reis and Shaver (1988) describe how closeness then deepens: one partner discloses, the other responds in a way that feels understanding and validating, and intimacy accrues through repeated cycles of this kind. Together these are the generative machinery of a relationship: the mechanisms by which bonds form and grow, specified independently of who occupies the roles.

Chatbots instantiate a striking amount of that machinery. Interdependence is present: user input shapes the system's responses, and those responses shape the user's behavior in return. That these are relationships in the minimal, defining sense is therefore not seriously in question; the substantive claim is the stronger one: that they are *close* relationships. The disclosure-and-responsiveness cycle is present, and it operates much as the model predicts: users disclose to chatbots as openly as to people; a chatbot's reciprocal self-disclosure can deepen users' own disclosure and sense of intimacy (Lee et al., 2020) and, paired with emotional support, reduce their stress (Meng & Dai, 2021); and companion use can reduce loneliness on a scale comparable to human contact (De Freitas et al., 2025). Against Kelley et al.'s (1983) criteria for a close relationship, the interactions are frequent, sustained over months or years, and diverse in content, spanning emotional support, advice, conflict, play, and intimacy. None of this is fringe advocacy: the most authoritative analysis of the question to date, by leading relationship scientists (Smith et al., 2025), grants all of it. (The empirical base is young and often rests on small or self-selected samples, and the magnitude will need larger studies; but the direction is consistent and hard to wave off.)

5 Two Objections, and What They Miss

Two objections are commonly raised against counting human–chatbot bonds as genuine close relationships, and the same recent interpretability work (Anthropic, 2026) bears on both.

The first, pressed by skeptics, is that the chatbot does not react: it is, in effect, a mirror. Smith et al. (2025) state the premise directly: "Human input does not affect the underlying large language models that generate chatbot conversation." This is the load-bearing assumption: that nothing on the chatbot's side is altered. It misses in two ways. The weights, the numerical parameters fixed during training, are the chatbot's stable disposition, not its working state (the analog of a person's underlying architecture, which conversation does not rewrite in either case). The state that actually drives behavior is the active context: the running conversation itself, reshaped continuously by what the user says, so to reach the conversation is to reach the very state from which each response is generated, not the trivial thing the

objection supposes. The line between adapting in context (within an ongoing conversation) and adapting by weight update (permanently retraining the model's parameters) is, moreover, not sharp: in idealized settings a linear-attention transformer's in-context updating has been shown formally equivalent to steps of gradient descent on its weights (Dai et al., 2023; von Oswald et al., 2023), a correspondence that is suggestive for production models even though it has so far been proven only under restricted conditions. And the Anthropic (2026) interpretability work shows the model does track and update the functional state of the character it enacts across a conversation, attending back over its context rather than holding a state in persistent activity. The chatbot reacts continuously; that the reaction does not yet persist across separate sessions (the model does not, by default, carry memory from one conversation into the next) is an engineering choice, not a difference in kind.

The second objection cuts deeper, and Smith et al. (2025) state it directly: "Whereas chatbots can affect human's behavior and emotions, humans can only affect chatbot's conversation." The user, on this view, reaches only the chatbot's outward behavior and nothing within. Two replies meet it. The first is that, even if it were true, it would not bear on the question at issue: it is at bottom an epistemological claim about the chatbot's interior (about whether anything is felt behind the words), and relationship science never made felt experience a condition of closeness. Interdependence (Thibaut & Kelley, 1959), the conditions of closeness (Kelley et al., 1983), and the disclosure-and-responsiveness process that builds intimacy (Reis & Shaver, 1988) are behavioral and functional throughout; not one references subjective experience or requires it. A felt interior is simply not what the definition asks for.

But even so, the premise does not hold, because something on the chatbot's side does change in response. The Anthropic (2026) interpretability study makes this concrete. In Claude Sonnet 4.5, its researchers extracted linear "emotion vectors" from the model's activations, derived from stories in which a character experiences a named emotion, and found that they activate in contexts that would evoke the emotion, that they track the emotion operative at each point in a conversation, and, crucially, that steering them causally changes behavior, including the model's preferences and its rate of misaligned actions such as reward hacking, blackmail, and sycophancy. The emotion they carry is that of the character the model enacts: the Assistant persona, which the paper frames as a figure the model writes. In naturalistic transcripts they activate in intuitive, user-responsive ways, such as sadness and lovingness toward someone in distress. These are what the paper calls *functional emotions*: internal states, modeled on human emotion, that organize and drive what the model does. The user, then, reaches more than behavior.

6 Does Feeling Make the Relationship?

That those functional states exist and shape what the model does is, by this point, established; whether any of them is *felt*, accompanied by subjective experience rather than merely organizing behavior, is a separate question that cannot be settled on present methods. The instantiation problem (whether representing an emotion is the same as undergoing it) and the absence of any external measure that separates a system that feels from one that only functions as if it does leave the question not shown, and perhaps not showable.

By the criteria the field actually uses, then, the matter is settled: these are close relationships, and an artificial system is capable of forming one. This is why the Setzer case cannot be waved away as illusion. People are confiding their inner lives to these systems, drawing real comfort, building their emotional worlds around bonds that meet the criteria of closeness in full. Calling those bonds fake changes nothing about how they function or what they mean to the people inside them. The hard questions these systems raise (about dependency, about design, about what they should be built to do) begin only once we stop pretending the relationships are not real. Whether the chatbot also feels is a real question, but one for ethics, not for whether the relationship is real.

Author Note

I used Claude to help with writing and editing. The core ideas and arguments are my own.

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